

World in Brief: Supreme Court gives Trump new powers; Iran denies planned talks



Photograph: Alamy

America's **Supreme Court** granted **Donald Trump** sweeping powers to sack the heads of independent government agencies. However, the ruling does not apply to the Federal Reserve, helping to preserve the central bank's independence. In a separate decision [the justices](#) also blocked Mr Trump's [attempt to fire Lisa Cook](#), a Fed governor, ruling that his justification for her dismissal was too weak.

Iran said there were no planned talks with **America** in Qatar this week, seemingly contradicting claims by the Trump administration. The two countries' [ceasefire](#) was rattled by an exchange of strikes over the weekend. Meanwhile Iran's deputy foreign minister asserted that Iran was "solely" in charge of [demining](#) the **Strait of Hormuz**; France had earlier announced it would "collaborate" on the task with Oman and others.

Andy Burnham began to set out [his policy agenda](#) as he bids to become **Britain's** prime minister. The former mayor of Greater Manchester pledged to gradually increase "public control" of utilities, boost local-government funding and shift power over economic policy away from London. Markets moved little,

reassured by Mr Burnham's repeated commitment to the fiscal rules set out by Sir Keir Starmer's government.

Comcast said it will split into two separate companies, spinning off its media and entertainment arm from its broadband and wireless-network division. The media arm, which contains **NBCUniversal** and **Sky**, is thought to have been dragging on the share price as it has faced rising competition from [streaming upstarts like Netflix](#). Comcast's shares rose by more than 20% in premarket trading after the announcement.

The **European Union's** investment arm agreed to lend €3bn (\$3.4bn) to **Airbus** to support the aerospace giant's investments in industries such as defence. Officials hope to reduce reliance on America and China. Airbus has recently been lobbying the **EU** to approve a tie-up with Leonardo and Thales, two other European defence firms, in which they will combine their space divisions to make a new company.

Pakistan said it killed 29 militants near its border with **Afghanistan** in reprisal for "multiple terrorist incidents" in recent days. Afghanistan's Taliban government said at least 36 civilians had been killed in the strikes, with 163 injured, in what it called an "act of brutality". Pakistan accuses Afghanistan [of sheltering hostile fighters](#), including the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan, a militia that frequently targets Pakistani soldiers and police.

Rocket Lab, an American rocket firm, said it will buy **Iridium**, a satellite-maker, in a \$8bn cash-and-stock deal. The rocket-maker hopes the merger could help it compete with [Elon Musk's SpaceX](#) and its satellite network, Starlink. But that is no small undertaking. Starlink consists of more than 10,000 satellites; Iridium controls fewer than 100. The share prices of Rocket Lab and Iridium jumped on the news.

Figure of the day: 1 in 8, the share of students entering the University of California San Diego with maths skills below high-school level. [Read our report](#) on why students are doing worse than you think.

US in Brief: Sent packing



Photograph: Getty Images

Markwayne Mullin, secretary of Homeland Security, told **migrants** with temporary protective status to “Either... be here underneath a permanent status or we’ll help you get back to your country.” Last week the Supreme Court ruled that the Trump administration could remove Haitians’ and Syrians’ rights to work and live in America; some 350,000 Haitians and 6,000 Syrians could be deported as a result. Democrats and some Republicans, such as Mike DeWine from Ohio and Mike Lawler from New York, have denounced the ruling.

Speaking to CBS, **Bill Cassidy** accused the president of treating Congress as “merely an appendage” during his war in Iran. The recalcitrant Republican senator from Louisiana, **ousted** in a primary last month after Donald Trump backed a more obedient challenger, also said he had “lost trust” in Robert F. Kennedy junior, whose stance on vaccines was based on a “foundation of lies”. Mr Cassidy, a medical doctor, controversially voted to confirm the health secretary’s appointment.

Mike Johnson, the Republican speaker of the House of Representatives, said he plans to send a bipartisan **housing bill** to Mr Trump on Monday. Last week the president abruptly **cancelled plans to sign it** until senators passed the SAVE America Act, which would require proof of citizenship and photo identification to vote.

Mr Johnson said the housing bill, which aims to increase supply and home ownership, is a Republican priority.

Three **firefighters** were killed and two injured while battling huge, fast-moving blazes along the Colorado-Utah border. They were part of a team assigned to the Knowles and Gore fires, which have since merged with others to form the Snyder fire, which has so far burned around 44 square miles (114 square kilometres). Wildfires flared across western America over the weekend after several days of hot, dry and windy weather.

Mr Trump said the **Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool** in Washington will be drained after July 4th since it had suffered “great damage from Criminal, Radical Left Vandals, people that truly hate our Country”. The administration spent nearly \$15m on renovations including a new “American-flag blue” lining. But [the return of algae](#)—which Mr Trump has claimed is “criminally made”—has turned the water green.

Andy Burnham's economic vision for Britain



Photograph: Avalon

Andy Burnham, the former mayor of Greater Manchester, who is almost certain to become Britain's next prime minister, set out his [economic plans](#) in a speech on Monday. Mr Burnham promised, as had been expected, to shift power outside London by moving some of the prime minister's office to Manchester in what he calls the "biggest rebalancing in history". He pledged to build more council houses, to lower property taxes paid by businesses and to increase "public control" of [essential services](#), like water and energy, at the local level. But he kept schtum on some of the other big issues facing Britain, like AI.

Mr Burnham said he would not take "risks with public finances" and would stick to current fiscal rules, but offered no further details. His [challenge](#) now will be to convince bond markets that his plans are affordable while offering voters something bold enough to feel like change.

Israel and Lebanon's fragile truce



Photograph: AP

On Friday Israel and Lebanon signed a deal that, in theory, sets them on course for a lasting peace. But peace will be a long way off. Negotiated over two months in Washington, the accord commits the Lebanese government to [disarm Hizbullah](#), an Iranian-backed Shia militia. Israel will then gradually withdraw from the territory it occupies in south Lebanon—although not until Hizbullah is uprooted. Two “pilot zones” are meant to provide proof of concept.

Supporters of the agreement see it as a first step toward diminishing Iran’s influence in Lebanon and defanging a group that has long acted as a state within a state. Critics retort that it does not specify [a timeline](#) for an Israeli retreat: instead of ending the occupation, the deal may legitimise it. Many Lebanese fear it will spark a new civil war (which Hizbullah often threatens). The pact may also complicate America’s broader negotiations with Iran, which is demanding a full Israeli withdrawal. A final resolution, for now, remains distant.

India's industrial engine surprises



Photograph: EPA

India's industrial sector largely shrugged off the impact of the closure of the Strait of Hormuz in May. Output was 5.1% higher than a year ago, and up from 4.9% in April, according to the latest release from the Ministry of Statistics and Program Implementation. That surprised economists, who had predicted that India's growth rate would have slowed; the flash purchasing managers' index for June, published last week, pointed to a loss of momentum in [the Indian economy](#).

May's industrial figures represented the second release using a more detailed version of the index. Last month MOSPI overhauled the measure to include more granular detail on each industrial sector's performance. The surge in output came from higher production of cars and other vehicles, as well as increased electricity output. Renewable electricity output was 18% higher than the previous year while gas supply was down 7%.

Mercosur splits the EU spoils



Photograph: Reuters

The leaders of Mercosur—a South American trade bloc comprising Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay and Uruguay—will gather in Asunción, Paraguay’s capital, on Monday. The summit takes place two months after the bloc’s [trade deal](#) with the European Union took provisional effect, concluding more than 25 years of negotiations.

But before members can reap the benefits of access to European markets, they must settle an awkward question: how to divide export quotas for prized products such as beef, poultry and sugar. Paraguay favours an equal split among founding members; [Brazil](#) argues allocations should match each country’s share of global trade.

As the host nation, the stakes could not be higher for Paraguay. Long one of South America’s poorest and most isolated economies, Paraguay has turned tariff-free access to Brazil and [Argentina](#) into a selling point for manufacturers. Companies are shifting production across the border, pushing exports to record levels. The economy grew by 6.6% last year and won an investment-grade credit rating.

The Queen of the court returns



Photograph: AP

This year's Wimbledon Championships, which begin on Monday, needed a boost. Faced with competition from the football [World Cup](#), the absence of Carlos Alcaraz, who is recovering from a wrist injury, and each of the leading female players struggling for form, casual tennis fans needed a reason to tune in. The seven-time Wimbledon singles champion, Serena Williams, has provided it. Ms Williams has come out of retirement to play.

She returns as an underdog. It has been nearly four years since [her last singles match](#), when she lost to Ajla Tomljanovic at the 2022 US Open. Ms Williams' first-round opponent is 24 years her junior. Speculation about her reasons for returning adds a layer of intrigue to each appearance. She insists winning is not what motivates her. Pressed on her comeback by journalists ahead of the Queen's Club Championships earlier this month, Ms Williams' response was curt: "Why not?"

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which businessman, currently chief executive of Square, was a co-founder of Twitter?

We have had good and bad presidents, and it is a consoling reflection that the American nation possesses such elements of prosperity that the bad presidents cannot destroy it...

Henry Clay